

Totemic Symbolism And The Representation Of Deities In The Ritual Performance Traditions Of Ase And Ushie Kingdoms, Delta State, Nigeria: A Comparative Study

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Abstract

This study examines the totemic symbolism and representation of deities in the ritual performance traditions of the Ase and Ushie kingdoms in Ndokwa East Local Government Area of Delta State, Nigeria. It explores how sacred animals, ritual objects, shrines, festivals, and ceremonial performances function as symbolic expressions of indigenous religious beliefs and communal identity. The study is anchored on Totemism Theory and Symbolic Interactionism Theory, the study adopted a qualitative ethnographic research design. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews, participant observation and documentary sources, and analysed thematically using a comparative approach. The findings reveal that although Ase and Ushie share a common historical ancestry, their ritual traditions have evolved in response to their distinct ecological environments, resulting in different cosmological orientations. In Ase, the crocodile symbolizes the goddess Usuei and reflects the community's riverine spirituality, while in Ushie, the iguana represents ancestral authority associated with the founding ancestor, Oduga. The study further establishes that ritual objects, shrines, masquerades, and festivals such as the Erishi and Ojie festivals function as symbolic media through which relationships between the human and spiritual worlds are enacted and sustained. It concludes that ritual performance constitutes a dynamic cultural institution that preserves indigenous knowledge, reinforces social cohesion and sustains cultural continuity. The study contributes to scholarship on African indigenous religion and performance by providing a comparative analysis of two relatively under-researched ritual traditions in the Niger Delta.

Keywords: Totemism, Ritual Performance, Symbolism, Deities, Indigenous Religion, Ase Kingdom, Ushie Kingdom.

Introduction

Ritual performance occupies a central position in African indigenous societies, serving as a dynamic medium through which religious beliefs, cultural values, historical memories and communal identities are expressed and transmitted across generations. Unlike ordinary social activities, ritual performances embody symbolic actions that mediate the relationship between the physical and spiritual worlds, providing communities with structured avenues for communicating with deities, ancestral spirits and supernatural forces. Across Africa, rituals are

enacted through festivals, masquerades, sacrifices, sacred dances, chants, processions and the use of ritual objects, each reflecting the cosmological worldview and cultural heritage of the people. As Mbiti (1969) observes, African religion permeates every aspect of life, making ritual performance an indispensable institution for preserving indigenous knowledge and sustaining social cohesion.

One of the most distinctive features of African ritual traditions is the extensive use of symbolism. Symbols function as repositories of religious meaning, cultural identity and collective memory, enabling communities to represent abstract spiritual realities through tangible objects, sacred animals, shrines, colours, costumes and ceremonial performances. Within most African societies, sacred animals occupy a particularly important place as totemic representations of divine authority, ancestral presence and communal identity. These totemic symbols are not merely elements of the natural environment but are revered as sacred entities that embody the moral values, historical experiences and religious beliefs of the communities that venerate them. Consequently, ritual performances become symbolic enactments through which the relationship between humanity and the supernatural is continually reaffirmed.

The Niger Delta region of Nigeria possesses a rich and diverse heritage of indigenous ritual performances that continue to shape the religious and socio-cultural life of most communities. Despite increasing influences of modernization, globalization, Christianity and urbanization, numerous indigenous communities have maintained elaborate ritual traditions characterized by sacred festivals, masquerade performances, shrines, ritual objects and the veneration of deities and ancestors. These ritual systems remain important mechanisms for preserving cultural heritage, reinforcing communal solidarity, legitimizing traditional authority and transmitting indigenous knowledge from one generation to another. They also provide valuable insights into the philosophical foundations of African cosmology and indigenous systems of performance.

Among the indigenous communities of the Niger Delta, the Ase and Ushie kingdoms in Ndokwa East Local Government Area of Delta State present compelling examples of vibrant ritual traditions rooted in distinct historical experiences and ecological environments. Although both communities trace their historical origins to the ancient Benin Kingdom, their subsequent settlement patterns have shaped different cosmological orientations and ritual practices. Ase, situated within a predominantly riverine environment, has developed ritual traditions centered on aquatic deities, sacred waterways and water-related symbolism. Ushie, by contrast, evolved within a terrestrial environment where ancestral traditions, sacred forests and land-based shrines occupy central positions in religious and cultural life. These environmental differences have profoundly influenced the symbolic systems through which each community represents spiritual authority and expresses its indigenous worldview.

Central to the ritual traditions of both communities is the use of sacred animals as totemic symbols. In Ase, the crocodile is revered as the sacred manifestation of the goddess Usuei, symbolizing divine protection, fertility and the spiritual significance of the river. In Ushie, the iguana occupies a comparable position as a sacred representation of ancestral authority and communal continuity associated with the founding ancestor, Oduga. Beyond these sacred animals, both communities employ shrines, ritual staffs, white chalk (Nzu), masquerades, ceremonial costumes, chants, dances and festivals as symbolic media through which religious beliefs are enacted and transmitted. These symbolic elements transform ritual performances

into living expressions of indigenous spirituality and cultural identity.

Scholars of African religion and performance have long recognized the significance of ritual symbolism in maintaining social order and expressing collective values. Turner (1969) conceptualizes ritual as a form of social drama through which communities negotiate social relationships and reaffirm shared beliefs. Similarly, Durkheim (1912/1995) argues that totems function as sacred symbols representing both divine authority and the collective identity of society. Within African theatre scholarship, Amankulor (1985) and Drewal and Drewal (1992) demonstrate that ritual festivals and masquerades possess sophisticated performative structures that integrate religious symbolism, dramatic action, music, dance and visual spectacle. These studies have significantly advanced understanding of African ritual performance as an indigenous theatrical tradition.

Despite these important contributions, existing scholarship has concentrated largely on the ritual traditions of major Nigerian ethnic groups such as the Yoruba, Igbo, Edo and Efik, while comparatively little attention has been devoted to the indigenous ritual systems of smaller communities in the Niger Delta. Consequently, the symbolic meanings of sacred animals, ritual objects, shrines and deities within the ritual performances of the Ase and Ushie kingdoms remain insufficiently documented and critically analysed. More importantly, few studies have undertaken a comparative examination of how environmental settings, historical experiences, and cosmological beliefs influence the representation of deities through ritual performance in these neighbouring communities. This gap limits scholarly understanding of the diversity and complexity of indigenous ritual traditions in the Niger Delta.

This study addresses this gap by undertaking a comparative analysis of totemic symbolism and the representation of deities in the ritual performance traditions of Ase and Ushie kingdoms in Delta State, Nigeria. Specifically, it examines the historical foundations of their ritual systems, the symbolic roles of sacred animals and ritual objects, the functions of shrines and festivals and the ways in which ritual performances mediate relationships between the human and spiritual worlds. Drawing on *Totemism Theory* and *Symbolic Interactionism*, the study argues that ritual performances in both communities constitute dynamic symbolic systems through which indigenous religious beliefs are preserved, communal identities are reinforced and cultural continuity is sustained. In doing so, the article contributes to the growing scholarship on African indigenous religion, ritual performance, and cultural heritage by providing one of the first comprehensive comparative analyses of the ritual

Ritual Performance in African Traditional Religion

Ritual performance occupies a central position in African Traditional Religion (ATR), functioning as a medium through which communities express religious beliefs, preserve cultural heritage and sustain relationships with deities, ancestors and the spiritual world. Rituals encompass festivals, masquerades, sacrifices, chants, dances, music and other ceremonial practices that reinforce communal identity and cultural continuity. Although scholars generally agree on the centrality of ritual in African societies, they differ in their emphasis on its religious, social and performative dimensions.

Mbiti (1969) presents ritual as an inseparable component of African life, arguing that religion

permeates every aspect of social existence. His work remains foundational because it situates ritual within the lived experiences of African communities rather than treating religion as a separate institutional sphere. However, Mbiti's broad treatment of African religion has been criticized for presenting African societies as relatively homogeneous, thereby overlooking regional variations and localized ritual traditions. Contemporary scholars have sought to address this limitation by emphasizing the diversity and adaptability of African ritual systems. Ukah (2020), for instance, argues that indigenous religious traditions continue to evolve in response to globalization, Christianity, urbanization and socio-economic transformation while retaining their symbolic foundations.

Turner (1969) extends this understanding by conceptualizing ritual as a form of "social drama" through which communities negotiate conflict, reaffirm shared values and restore social equilibrium. His emphasis on ritual symbols as multivocal communicative devices provides a valuable analytical framework for interpreting the layered meanings embedded in indigenous performances. Nevertheless, Turner's model was developed primarily from studies of the Ndembu of Zambia and therefore requires contextual adaptation when applied to the diverse ritual traditions of the Niger Delta. Recent heritage studies similarly recognize ritual as a dynamic cultural process that continually reconstructs communal identity through collective participation rather than simply preserving inherited traditions (UNESCO, 2023).

From a performance perspective, Schechner (2003) argues that ritual and theatre share common performative structures, including symbolic action, audience participation, prescribed sequences, movement, music and spectacle. His approach broadens the understanding of ritual beyond its religious significance by highlighting its aesthetic and performative dimensions. Similarly, Amankulor (1985) demonstrates that African festivals embody the essential elements of theatre through dramatic enactment, music, dance, costume, dialogue and audience participation, while Drewal and Drewal (1992) illustrate that Yoruba masquerade performances are embodied religious experiences in which performance, spirituality and communal participation converge. More recent scholarship equally emphasizes indigenous festivals as forms of intangible cultural heritage that preserve historical memory while simultaneously adapting to contemporary socio-cultural realities (UNESCO, 2023; Falola & Afolabi, 2023).

Collectively, these studies establish ritual performance as a multidimensional institution encompassing religious, social, theatrical and cultural functions. However, they focus predominantly on major African societies such as the Yoruba and Ndembu, with comparatively limited attention to smaller indigenous communities in the Niger Delta. This leaves significant gaps in understanding how localized ecological settings and historical experiences shape ritual performance traditions in communities such as Ase and Ushie.

Totemic Symbolism in African Indigenous Religion

Totemic symbolism represents one of the most enduring expressions of African indigenous religious thought, providing tangible representations of spiritual authority, communal identity, and ancestral continuity. While scholars generally agree that totems function as sacred symbols, they differ in explaining the origins and significance of these symbolic relationships.

Durkheim (1912/1995) argues that the totem simultaneously represents the deity and the society

that venerates it, making it a symbol of collective consciousness and social solidarity. His interpretation remains highly influential because it links religious symbolism with social cohesion. However, Durkheim's theory has been criticized for emphasizing the collective social function of religion while paying comparatively less attention to local cosmological meanings and historical contexts that shape particular ritual traditions.

Frazer (1922), by contrast, interprets totemism primarily as an early form of religious organization characterized by sacred relationships between human groups and particular animals or plants. Although his work provides valuable insight into the role of myths, taboos and ritual obligations, his evolutionary perspective has been widely challenged for portraying indigenous religions as developmental stages leading to supposedly more advanced religious systems.

African scholars provide perspectives that more closely reflect indigenous realities. Mbiti (1969) observes that sacred animals frequently serve as manifestations of ancestral spirits or divine powers, while Nabofa (1994) argues that religious symbols derive their significance from the cultural meanings attributed to them within specific communities. More recent studies similarly contend that totemic symbols should be understood within their local ecological and cultural contexts rather than through universal evolutionary models. Olupona (2014) argues that indigenous religious symbols derive meaning from lived communal experience, while Ukah (2020) emphasizes that sacred symbols continue to evolve as communities negotiate cultural continuity amid social change.

Despite these contributions, relatively few studies have examined how sacred animals function simultaneously as religious symbols, performative elements and expressions of communal identity within the ritual traditions of smaller Niger Delta communities. This limitation underscores the need for comparative studies that investigate localized forms of totemic symbolism.

Representation of Deities in African Ritual Performance

The representation of deities through ritual performance is a defining characteristic of African indigenous religions. Rather than existing solely as abstract spiritual entities, deities become symbolically present through masquerades, shrines, ritual objects, sacrifices, chants, dances and ceremonial performances that enable interaction between the human and spiritual worlds.

Drewal and Drewal (1992) argue that masquerades should not be understood as theatrical impersonations but as living embodiments of spiritual beings, temporarily dissolving the boundary between performer and deity. Similarly, Ray (2000) demonstrates that ritual performances legitimize traditional authority by symbolically connecting political leadership with divine sanction. Together, these perspectives highlight the inseparable relationship between ritual performance, religious belief and governance within African societies.

Recent scholarship emphasizes that ritual performance is neither static nor merely preservative but continually adapts to changing social realities while retaining its symbolic foundations. Ukah (2020) argues that African indigenous religions increasingly negotiate the pressures of globalization, religious pluralism and modernization without abandoning their symbolic systems. Likewise, Olupona (2014) maintains that contemporary indigenous religious practices

continue to reshape communal identities while preserving fundamental cosmological principles. These perspectives challenge earlier portrayals of indigenous religion as static and instead recognize ritual as a dynamic process of cultural continuity and transformation.

Although existing studies provide valuable insights into the representation of deities, they rarely undertake comparative analyses of how different ecological environments influence the symbolic construction of divine authority within neighbouring communities. Consequently, the relationship between environment, cosmology and ritual representation remains insufficiently explored.

Indigenous Ritual Performance in the Niger Delta

The Niger Delta possesses one of Africa's richest concentrations of indigenous ritual traditions, shaped by diverse ecological environments, migration histories and cosmological beliefs. Existing scholarship has documented ritual performances among groups such as the Ijaw, Urhobo, Itsekiri, Isoko and Ogoni, demonstrating that festivals, masquerades, ancestral worship, and river deities remain central to cultural identity and indigenous governance.

Recent studies further emphasize that indigenous festivals perform significant cultural, educational and heritage functions by preserving historical memory and strengthening communal resilience in the face of modernization and globalization (UNESCO, 2023; Falola & Afolabi, 2023). This contemporary perspective extends earlier anthropological studies by recognizing ritual festivals as important elements of Africa's intangible cultural heritage.

Despite these contributions, research has largely concentrated on the region's larger ethnic groups, leaving smaller communities comparatively underrepresented. In particular, the ritual traditions of the Ase and Ushie kingdoms have received little sustained scholarly attention. Existing accounts are largely descriptive, focusing on isolated customs rather than analysing the symbolic relationships among sacred animals, ritual objects, shrines, deities and performance practices.

Furthermore, no known study has undertaken a systematic comparative investigation of how differing ecological environments shape the cosmological orientations and ritual performances of these neighbouring communities. This represents an important gap within African performance scholarship because it limits understanding of the diversity and complexity of indigenous ritual systems in the Niger Delta.

The present study addresses this gap by comparatively examining totemic symbolism and representation of deities in the ritual traditions of Ase and Ushie communities. By integrating perspectives from performance studies, anthropology, indigenous religion and heritage studies, it extends existing knowledge beyond descriptive ethnography to demonstrate how ritual performance functions simultaneously as religious expression, symbolic communication, cultural preservation and identity construction

Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored on *Totemism Theory* and *Symbolic Interactionism Theory*. These complementary theoretical perspectives provide an appropriate framework for understanding

how sacred animals, ritual objects, shrines, festivals and ceremonial performances function as symbolic representations of deities and communal identity in the ritual traditions of the Ase and Ushie kingdoms. While *Totemism Theory* explains the sacred relationship between communities and their totemic symbols, *Symbolic Interactionism Theory* illuminates how meanings attached to these symbols are created, negotiated and sustained through ritual performance.

Totemism Theory

Totemism Theory was systematically developed by the French sociologist Émile Durkheim in *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912/1995). Durkheim examined the religious practices of Australian Aboriginal societies and argued that totems are not merely sacred animals or objects but symbolic representations of both divine authority and the collective identity of the community. According to Durkheim (1912/1995), “totem is at once the symbol of the god and of the society” (p. 208). In this sense, the sacredness attributed to a totem reflects the collective beliefs, values and moral consciousness of the society that venerates it.

Durkheim further contends that religious symbols derive their significance from the meanings collectively assigned to them by members of a community. Totems therefore serve not only as objects of religious reverence but also as unifying emblems that reinforce social cohesion, regulate moral behaviour, and preserve communal identity. Through rituals, festivals, sacrifices, and ceremonial observances, communities continually reaffirm the sacred relationship between themselves and their totemic symbols, thereby strengthening both religious commitment and social solidarity.

Within African indigenous religions, totemic beliefs frequently manifest through the veneration of particular animals, plants, rivers, forests, or natural phenomena that are regarded as sacred embodiments of deities or ancestral spirits. Such sacred symbols are protected by cultural taboos and ritual prescriptions that regulate communal behaviour and reinforce indigenous systems of belief. Totemic symbols therefore perform religious, cultural, ecological and social functions simultaneously.

The relevance of *Totemism Theory* to the present study lies in its ability to explain the symbolic significance of the sacred animals that occupy central positions within the ritual traditions of Ase and Ushie. In Ase Kingdom, the crocodile is revered as the sacred representation of the goddess Usuei, symbolizing divine protection, fertility and the spiritual authority of the riverine environment. Similarly, in Ushie Kingdom, the iguana functions as a sacred emblem associated with the founding ancestor, Oduga, symbolizing ancestral continuity, communal identity and spiritual protection. These animals are not merely components of the natural environment; rather, they embody collective religious beliefs and serve as enduring symbols of the communities' relationships with their deities and ancestors. *Totemism Theory* therefore provides an appropriate framework for interpreting the symbolic roles of sacred animals and understanding how they contribute to the preservation of indigenous religious traditions and communal identity.

Symbolic Interactionism Theory

Symbolic Interactionism Theory, originated in the works of George Herbert Mead (1934) and

was later developed into a comprehensive sociological theory by Herbert Blumer (1969). The theory is founded on the proposition that social reality is constructed through interaction and that individuals act toward people, objects and events based on the meanings those entities hold for them. Blumer (1969, p. 2) summarizes the theory in three central premises: first, human beings act toward things according to the meanings those things have for them; second, these meanings arise from social interaction; and third, meanings are continuously interpreted and modified through social experience.

Unlike perspectives that regard symbols as possessing fixed or inherent meanings, Symbolic Interactionism argues that meanings are socially created, negotiated and reproduced through communication and collective action. Rituals therefore become important sites where symbols acquire significance and where communities reaffirm shared interpretations of sacred objects, deities and ceremonial practices. Through repeated participation in ritual performances, members of a community internalize these meanings and transmit them across generations, thereby ensuring cultural continuity.

In African indigenous societies, ritual performances constitute symbolic interactions through which participants communicate with deities, ancestral spirits and one another. Sacred objects such as shrines, ritual staffs, white chalk (Nzu), masquerades, costumes, chants, dances and ceremonial processions derive their significance from the meanings collectively attributed to them within the cultural context of the community. Their effectiveness lies not merely in their physical form but in the shared beliefs and symbolic interpretations that govern their ritual use. *Symbolic Interactionism* is particularly relevant to this study because it explains how ritual performances in Ase and Ushie function as communicative processes through which spiritual realities are expressed and reinforced. During festivals such as the *Erishi Festival* in Ase and the *Ojie Festival* in Ushie, participants collectively interpret and enact symbolic meanings associated with sacred animals, deities, shrines, masquerades, and ritual objects. These performances reaffirm communal values, strengthen social cohesion, legitimize traditional authority, and maintain continuity between the living, ancestors and the spiritual world. The theory therefore provides a useful framework for understanding ritual performance as a dynamic process of meaning-making rather than merely a sequence of ceremonial activities.

Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative ethnographic research design to investigate the totemic symbolism and representation of deities in the ritual performance traditions of Ase and Ushie kingdoms in Ndokwa East Local Government Area of Delta State, Nigeria. The study employed purposive sampling techniques to select traditional rulers, chief priests, ritual custodians, community elders and other knowledgeable participants.

Data were collected through semi-structured interviews, participant observation and documentary sources, including books, journal articles and archival materials. The data were analysed thematically and comparatively to identify similarities and differences in the ritual traditions of the two communities. The analysis were guided by *Totemism Theory* and *Symbolic Interactionism Theory*, which provided the framework for interpreting the symbolic roles of sacred animals, ritual objects, shrines, deities and ritual performances. Ethical standards were observed through informed consent, permission from traditional authorities and respect for

indigenous cultural protocols.

Historical Origins and Ritual Foundations: Findings reveal that both Ase and Ushie kingdoms trace their historical origins to migration from the ancient Benin Kingdom, a shared ancestry that continues to shape their indigenous religious traditions and ritual institutions. Despite this common historical background, their distinct ecological environments have produced different ritual orientations. Ase, situated within a riverine landscape, developed ritual traditions centred on aquatic deities and water symbolism, whereas Ushie's terrestrial environment fostered ritual practices rooted in ancestral veneration, sacred forests and land-based shrines. These findings suggest that while migration established a common cultural foundation, environmental conditions significantly influenced the evolution of ritual performance in both communities.

Findings and Discussion

Historical Origins and Ritual Foundations

Findings reveal that both Ase and Ushie kingdoms trace their historical origins to migration from the ancient Benin Kingdom, a shared ancestry that continues to shape their indigenous religious traditions and ritual institutions. Despite this common historical background, their distinct ecological environments have produced different ritual orientations. Ase, situated within a riverine landscape, developed ritual traditions centred on aquatic deities and water symbolism, while Ushie's terrestrial environment fostered ritual practices rooted in ancestral veneration, sacred forests and land-based shrines. These findings suggest that while migration established a common cultural foundation, environmental conditions significantly influenced the evolution of ritual performance in both communities. This supports Turner's (1969) view that ritual reflects the social and cultural realities of a community. The findings also align with Ukah (2020), who argues that African indigenous religions continuously adapt to changing environmental and social contexts while preserving their core cosmological principles. Similarly, Olupona (2014) observes that indigenous religious traditions remain dynamic systems shaped by history, geography and communal experience rather than static cultural relics.

Language and Ritual Communication

The study found that ritual language constitutes an essential component of ceremonial performance in both communities. Although Ase predominantly uses the Eboh dialect and Ushie the Ukwani dialect, ritual communication in both communities is expressed through chants, invocations, praise poetry, prayers and incantations that facilitate communication with deities and ancestral spirits. The effectiveness of these verbal expressions derives not only from their linguistic content but also from their ritual performance, including tone, rhythm and prescribed modes of delivery. These findings support Blumer's (1969) assertion that meanings are socially constructed through symbolic interaction. They further correspond with Finnegan's (2012) observation that oral performance traditions preserve indigenous knowledge through symbolic speech, performance and collective participation, while Ukah (2020) emphasizes that ritual language remains central to the transmission of African religious identity despite contemporary social transformations.

Myth and Cosmology

The findings indicate that mythology provides the philosophical foundation for ritual performance in both communities. Ase mythology is predominantly associated with river deities and aquatic spirituality, while Ushie mythology centres on ancestral migration narratives and the continuing influence of ancestral spirits. Despite these differences, both communities perceive ritual performance as the principal means through which relationships between the physical and spiritual worlds are maintained. This confirms Mbiti's (1969) observation that African cosmology integrates religion with everyday life. Contemporary scholarship likewise emphasizes that African cosmologies are continually reinterpreted through ritual performance and collective memory rather than merely preserved as historical traditions (Olupona, 2014; Ukah, 2020).

Sacred Animals and Totemic Symbolism

A major finding of the study is the central role of sacred animals as totemic representations of divine authority and communal identity. In Ase, the crocodile symbolizes the goddess *Usuei* and represents protection, fertility, and the sacredness of the river. In Ushie, the iguana symbolizes the founding ancestor, *Oduga* and embodies ancestral authority and communal continuity. Both animals are protected by cultural taboos that prohibit their destruction, reflecting their sacred status within the religious life of the communities. These findings strongly validate Durkheim's (1912/1995) theory that totems function simultaneously as symbols of divine power and collective identity. They also support Nabofa's (1994) argument that religious symbols derive meaning from indigenous cultural contexts and resonate with UNESCO's (2003) recognition of indigenous beliefs and ritual practices as important elements of intangible cultural heritage worthy of preservation.

Ritual Symbols and Sacred Objects

The study found that ritual objects such as the *Ofor* staff, *Ojji* staff, and *Nzu* (white chalk) occupy important positions within the ceremonial traditions of both communities. These objects symbolize spiritual authority, legitimacy, purity and divine blessing while simultaneously serving practical roles during ritual performances. Although their specific ritual applications differ according to local traditions, they collectively reinforce religious authority and communal values. Their continued use demonstrates the enduring significance of material symbolism in preserving indigenous religious traditions. This finding is consistent with Ray's (2000) argument that sacred objects mediate relationships between the physical and spiritual worlds. It also reflects recent heritage scholarship, which recognizes ritual objects as important repositories of indigenous knowledge and cultural identity (UNESCO, 2003; Ukah, 2020).

Shrines and Sacred Spaces

The findings reveal that shrines constitute the spiritual centres of ritual activities in both Ase and Ushie. In Ase, shrines dedicated to *Usuei*, *Okpotu*, *Igerige*, and *Onyeuku* are closely associated with riverine deities and aquatic spirituality. In Ushie, sacred sites such as *Ebii Lake*, *Ojie*, and *Anagba-Obaa* function primarily as centres of ancestral worship and communal rituals. Despite their different cosmological orientations, shrines in both communities serve similar functions as sacred spaces for sacrifice, prayer, divination and communication with spiritual beings. These

findings support Ray's (2000) position that sacred spaces provide the institutional foundation of African religious practice. They further correspond with Olupona's (2014) observation that sacred landscapes remain fundamental to indigenous religious identity because they embody historical memory, spirituality and communal continuity.

Representation of Deities

The study established that deities in both communities are represented through ritual performances rather than abstract religious concepts. Sacred festivals, masquerades, ritual objects, shrines, sacrifices, chants and ceremonial processions collectively make spiritual beings visible within communal life. While Ase emphasizes water deities associated with protection and fertility, Ushie places greater emphasis on ancestral deities responsible for moral order and territorial protection. These symbolic representations demonstrate that ritual performance functions as a living expression of indigenous religious belief, enabling participants to experience the presence of the divine through ceremonial action. This finding supports Drewal and Drewal's (1992) conception of masquerades as embodied spiritual manifestations and aligns with Ukah's (2020) view that ritual performance remains a dynamic means through which African communities reinterpret and sustain indigenous religious traditions.

Ritual Festivals as Performance

The *Erishi Festival* of Ase and the *Ojie Festival* of Ushie emerged as the principal ritual performances through which communal beliefs are enacted and transmitted. Both festivals incorporate ritual dances, masquerades, drumming, chants, sacrifices, processions and dramatic reenactments of sacred narratives. While *Erishi* emphasizes aquatic spirituality and the community's relationship with water deities, *Ojie* celebrates ancestral heritage and communal continuity. These findings support Schechner's (2003) proposition that ritual and theatre share common performative structures and affirm Amankulor's (1985) view that African festivals constitute authentic forms of indigenous theatre. They also correspond with UNESCO's (2003) conception of ritual festivals as forms of intangible cultural heritage that preserve collective memory through performance and reinforce contemporary scholarship advocating the safeguarding of indigenous performance traditions.

Ritual Performance, Cultural Identity and Social Cohesion

The study demonstrates that ritual performance extends beyond religious observance to function as an important mechanism for preserving cultural identity and strengthening social cohesion. Participation in festivals, masquerades, sacrifices and ceremonial performances reinforces communal solidarity, transmits indigenous knowledge and reaffirms shared historical memory. Despite differences in cosmological orientation, both Ase and Ushie employ ritual performance as a means of preserving their cultural heritage and sustaining continuity between past and present generations. These findings reinforce Turner's (1969) conception of ritual as a social institution that promotes collective identity while supporting Durkheim's (1912/1995) argument that shared religious symbols contribute to social integration and communal stability. They further support contemporary scholarship which argues that indigenous ritual performances remain effective mechanisms for cultural resilience, identity

formation and heritage preservation in the face of modernization and globalization (Ukah, 2020; UNESCO, 2003; Olupona, 2014).

Conclusion

This study comparatively examined the totemic symbolism and representation of deities in the ritual performance traditions of the Ase and Ushie kingdoms of Delta State, Nigeria. The findings reveal that ritual performance in both communities functions as a dynamic cultural and religious institution through which indigenous beliefs, communal identity and historical memory are expressed and sustained. Although the two communities share a common historical ancestry, their ritual traditions have evolved in response to their distinct ecological settings, resulting in different cosmological orientations reflected in their sacred animals, shrines, deities and ritual festivals. The crocodile in Ase and the iguana in Ushie emerge as significant totemic symbols that embody divine authority, ancestral heritage and communal values. Similarly, ritual objects, sacred spaces, masquerades and festivals serve as symbolic media through which the relationship between the physical and spiritual worlds is enacted and reaffirmed. By integrating *Totemism Theory* and *Symbolic Interactionism Theory*, the study demonstrates that ritual performances are not merely ceremonial practices but complex symbolic systems that preserve indigenous knowledge, reinforce social cohesion and sustain cultural continuity. The study contributes to African performance scholarship by providing a comparative understanding of two relatively underexplored ritual traditions in the Niger Delta and highlights the continuing relevance of indigenous ritual practices in contemporary cultural discourse.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of the study, the following recommendations are made:

- i. Indigenous ritual festivals such as the *Erishi* and *Ojie festivals* should be systematically documented and preserved through archival, audiovisual and heritage conservation initiatives to safeguard their cultural and historical significance.
- ii. Further comparative studies on the ritual performance traditions of indigenous communities in the Niger Delta should be encouraged to expand scholarship in Theatre and Performance Studies, Anthropology, Religious Studies and African cultural heritage.
- iii. Government agencies, cultural institutions and traditional authorities should collaborate to promote and protect indigenous festivals, sacred sites and ritual practices through appropriate cultural preservation policies and community-based heritage programmes.
- iv. Institutions of higher learning should strengthen the inclusion of indigenous ritual performance, symbolism and African religious traditions in Theatre Arts and related curricula to foster greater appreciation and preservation of Nigeria's rich cultural heritage

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